



and semifinals for a bunch of games, all of which were held on Day 1, while the grand finales were all held on Day 2. Quarterfinals and semifinals for DOTA 2 and Counter Strike Go were already on from as early as 10 AM on the first day, with a great bunch of casters keeping the audience enthralled with their enthusiasm. After a busy day of eliminations, Day 2 had all the finales that the assembled audience was really looking forward to.

In DOTA 2, the five-men team of Beyond Infinity (sponsored by ASUS) won against Invisible Wings in a hard-fought series of games by a narrow 2-1 margin. Beyond Infinity won the first game, only to see Invisible Wings hammer them in the second game. As expected the third game was a cagey affair, with both teams taking calculated risks and it was a nail-biter to the finish as Beyond Infinity nicked it at the end. They pocketed a cool ₹1.5 lacs in team prize money. Both teams qualified for the grand finale of ESL India Premiership to be held later this year.

It was a similar scene in CS:GO, the night's mega event, drawing the most crowd, as Indian pro-gaming's pride and glory Team Brutality took on Invisible Wings in three different maps – Cobblestone, Dust 2 and Mirage. Invisible Wings knocked Team Brutality out of the first game on Cobblestone, only to see Team Brutality comeback from 0-8 down to win game two at 16-11 on Dust 2 – easily the best game of the match. It was all for nothing, though,

as unsung heroes Invisible Wings eventually shut out Team Brutality by winning the final game and clinching the best of three final by 2-1, thus pocketing ₹1.5 lacs.

Hearthstone finale saw Sankalp Sharma take the crown and win a well-deserved ₹25k. Competitions in Just Dance and Cosplaying were also held at the venue, which proved to be a good hit among the assembled crowd. The Just Dance competition was open for anyone to compete in, and it was great to see a youngster from the audience – who had come in to support some of his cosplayer friends – win the Just Dance competition and earn ₹10k in the process. Not bad for shaking a leg on a rainy Sunday, eh?

Beyond pro gaming...

Apart from the pro-gaming competitions held in the ESL India Premiership's Pune leg, the venue also had partner booths on display. Technology brands like ASUS, Kingston and HTC Vive were seen showcasing their latest and greatest products, keeping the crowds busy on both days of the competition.

Both ASUS (under their Republic Of Gamers brand) and Kingston were title sponsors, and were displaying their latest RAM, SSD, headset, motherboards, gaming rigs and peripherals aimed at gamers. Both their booths had gaming PCs for people to try out and learn more about the components that separates a good PC from a truly great one. The HTC Vive booth, which was set up in a corner, was

truly a revelation of sorts, as it gave a lot of people their first real taste of just how VR is going to disrupt the gaming world. Volunteers had a chance to try out the yet-unreleased HTC Vive VR headset and try out a couple of VR game demos (powered off Steam VR), and this experience more than anything else left people with a real sense of wonder and unbridled joy at ESL India Premiership's Challenger Cup held in Pune.

This is just the tip of the iceberg as more ESL India Premiership heats are coming up in the months ahead. And we'll be bringing you all the action from these events, as pro-gaming in India really takes off in a big way. Stay tuned. *